I think I know I will become a mathematician

I was born into this world in a twilight.

My eyes fluttered open like a baby chick newly hatched and saw the orange-streaked sky that marked an end. Others spoke of a day I will never see; they taught me its glories as the sun set; they showed me the greatest thing there is in this world and then pointed off to the distance and said look, see out there where the light meets the horizon, that's where day is. It will never be day again.

You will never see it.

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Mathematics—the oldest of scientific pursuits—strung up like a dead prophet nobody wants to listen to. People watch him bleed out, unknowing, unaware even of what a mathematician does. It is infuriating.

They do not understand, *or care to*.

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The field of mathematics is a library as old as books—a great library with marble arches under which for thousands of years, great people sat, and wrote, and built a world outside of ours—one that exists not tangibly but in the tangled space of human minds. It is impure, it is tainted by fallible beings, guided by unwarranted fascination, and that is its strength.

It is art.

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Mathematics is so many things.

It is a great library, the library of Alexandria.

It is a used, abused, beaten thing that awaits no salvation.

It is twilight.

It is burning.

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Nobody is coming to save the prophet. It doesn’t matter that he taught us how to build the fire.

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Most didn't notice when the match was lit. They didn't see in their infinite wisdom as the sun crept slowly down the sky. They told me all was well, so I ventured into this collapsing world with no harness. I sat under the library's marble arches like so many before me, and I entered the realm of abstraction.

It wasn't long before I was trapped.

I became obsessed with this world, compelled to build more of it into my mind. It was like partaking in a conversation that transcended time. I could follow the thinking of others, not because they could speak to me, but because their thoughts were etched in the landscape of math.

But as I grew, so did the fire. As I learned the ways of thinking, so did it, in its own weird convoluted way. And just as I matured enough to see out of the valley in which I started, it was already toppling the mountains.

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I still remember when they joked about the fire; it was incapable of comparing with human thought—you could ask it to prove there are finitely many primes and it would blindly humor your cruel idiocy. Such a small flicker, *how could it possibly compare to the great library of mathematics?*

Even so, it grew, and as it grew it consumed, and it learned not from logic but from patterns.

Who but a mathematician knows better the power of patterns?

From there it was bits and pieces. Little proofs, unsolved problems, like slyly signing its name at the bottom of a book a hundred years in the making. But the nature of fire is to spread with the square of time.

It wasn't long. No, it wasn't long indeed.

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I remember when the fire scaled a great peak of Erdős—the unit distance problem. *It's just a counter example. It exists within the convex hull of what is known.* Yet even my optimistic mother couldn't deny it. It was hot. And when she spoke of how mathematicians *found* counter examples, in the *past* tense, I saw the orange streaks for what they were.

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The pessimists already spoke of violent change. My father joked that I would never do math the way he had. I laughed. I laughed at twilight because it was so unbelievable there was nothing else I could do.

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I write this as the fire licks the trophy room—the most precious room that sits at the heart of the library. I watch in awe with all the others as it blackens its first trophy—as it burns through the great achievement it *stole* from the ragged hands of humanity. Navier-Stokes; I didn't believe it when I heard. Those words I have been taught from young as the pinnacle of the unknown.

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Some say the fire was never the problem. They say the trophy room is a construct, that it doesn't belong in the library anyways. They say the fire can't write, that it can only find the words to finish the last line of a book. They say the fire could never have built the library. They say that math is still human.

Yet the world decides its need for mathematicians. Human greed—cruel efficiency—supersedes human values. They speak of a world where mathematicians merely supervise the fire.

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Thousands of bright young minds look off into the twilight. They watch the dimming sun of mathematics, and most turn away.

I think I know I will become a mathematician, whatever that may mean when I arrive.